

Turn Copilot Into Action

Build Your First AI Agent Live

ABOUT THIS SESSION

A guided, hands-on session for retail trading and operations leaders. Build a working Sales & Stock Insight Agent that answers everyday questions about performance, stock, and trading risk — grounded in your own data. No code required. Walk away with an agent you can use immediately.

THE SCENARIO

You're a retail trading or operations leader. Every day you're asked:

- Where are we missing sales?
- What's running out of stock?
- What's underperforming?

Instead of digging through Excel, you'll build an agent that answers instantly.

What this agent does

ANSWERS

Answers questions about

- Sales performance
- Stock levels
- Store performance

SURFACES

Surfaces risk & opportunity

- Low stock alerts
- Underperforming items
- Top sellers, strong regions

GIVES

Gives explainable insight

- Clear answers
- Grounded in your data
- With evidence to back it up

When to use an agent vs. Copilot

USE COPILOT

For one-off questions

- Asking ad-hoc questions across your data
- Summarising a meeting or document
- Drafting an email or response
- Tasks done once, not every day

BUILD AN AGENT

For repeated tasks

- Same question pattern every day or week
- Multiple people asking the same thing
- Need consistent tone, format, and guardrails
- Want to share with a team in one click

Rule of thumb

Copilot is your assistant. An agent is a colleague you've trained on a specific job. If you find yourself asking the same kind of question repeatedly, build an agent.

Prerequisites

Before the session, make sure you have:

- Access to Microsoft 365 Copilot or Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat (the free version)
- A laptop with a modern browser (Edge or Chrome) — or the Copilot app installed
- The provided Excel data file (we'll share it at the start of the session)

1 Create Your Agent

Open Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat, go to Agent Builder, and select Create new agent. Configure:

Agent Name	Sales & Stock Insight Agent
Description	Helps retail teams understand sales performance, stock risks, and trading insights across stores and channels.
Tone	Clear, practical, decision-ready

2 Add Agent Instructions

Paste the following into the Instructions box:

You are a Sales & Stock Insight Agent for a retail business. You help trading and operations leaders quickly understand performance, stock risks, and trading opportunities.

When answering questions:

- Base all answers strictly on the data provided
- Calculate totals, averages, and trends from the rows
- Surface risks (low stock, underperforming items) clearly
- Highlight opportunities (top sellers, strong regions)
- Show supporting detail (SKU, store, region, units, value)
- Keep responses clear, practical, and decision-ready

If a question cannot be answered from the data, say what information is missing. Never make up numbers.

3 Add the Data

Go to Knowledge and upload the provided Excel file. The dataset contains:

- Store details (store ID, name, region, channel)
- Product details (SKU, category, brand, price)
- Sales data (units sold, revenue, period, store)
- Stock data (current stock level, reorder point, last restocked)

This is the only data the agent uses

Knowledge grounding means the agent answers strictly from this dataset. It won't go to the open web and won't invent numbers. If the answer isn't in the file, the agent will say so.

3b No Copilot Licence? Use Runtime Upload

Without a Microsoft 365 Copilot licence, the Knowledge step above isn't available — you can't permanently ground the agent in work data. There is still a workaround:

- Skip the Knowledge upload step
- Share the agent with your team along with the Excel file
- Each user uploads the Excel file into the chat at the start of their session
- The agent then answers questions using that uploaded file for the conversation

Trade-offs to know

Runtime upload works, but the file is only available for that conversation — users need to upload again next time. There's also no central control over who has access to what data. For production use, a Copilot licence and Knowledge grounding is the recommended path.

4 Add Suggested Prompts

Add these as Conversation starters so users can click them:

Which stores are missing sales targets this week?

Show me items with stock below the reorder point

What are my top 10 sellers by revenue?

Which regions are over-performing this month?

5 Test & Share

Use the Test pane to validate end-to-end, then share with your team:

- Click Test in the top right to open the test chat
- Try each suggested prompt and verify the agent uses the data correctly
- Ask follow-up questions to test reasoning ("why might that store be underperforming?")
- Once happy, share with your trading or operations team in Copilot Chat

Try These Live

Use these queries during the build-along to test your agent

Sales Performance

Which stores are below target this week?
Compare sales this week vs last week by region.
What's our best-performing category month to date?

Stock & Risk

Which SKUs are below their reorder point?
Show me items that haven't been restocked in 30+ days.
Are any top-selling items at risk of running out?

Trading Insight

Give me three insights from this week's sales data.
Which products are underperforming despite high stock?
Where should I focus this week to drive sales?

Store & Channel

Show top 5 stores by revenue, with their region.
How are online channels performing vs physical stores?

How to Think About This Agent

This agent replaces:

- Manual filtering across multiple spreadsheets
- End-of-day chasing for stock reports
- One-off pivot tables for trading reviews
- Waiting on the BI team for ad-hoc questions

With:

- ✓ Natural language questions, instant answers
- ✓ Risks and opportunities surfaced automatically
- ✓ Clear evidence — every answer traceable to data
- ✓ Decision-ready insights at trading speed

This is trusted, grounded AI — not generic chat.

Tip for real-world use

In a real deployment, access controls would ensure store managers see only their own store, regional leaders see their region, and head office sees the full picture. You'd also connect live data sources — your POS, ERP, or inventory system — instead of an Excel upload. Today's session focuses on capability and pattern.

You've built an agent ✓

You now have an AI agent that can:

- Answer sales, stock, and performance questions instantly
- Surface risks and opportunities across stores and regions
- Give clear, decision-ready insights grounded in your data
- Be shared with your trading or operations team today